

Linear regression: Abalone growth and pH example

Callie Baker

2026-05-15

Table of contents

Set up	1
Abalone example	2
a. Questions and hypotheses	2
b. Cleaning	2
c. Exploratory data visualization	2
d. Abalone model	4
Model fitting	4
Diagnostics	4
Model summary	4
Generating predictions	5
Why generate model predictions?	6
Visualizing model predictions and data	7
Creating a table with model coefficients, 95% confidence intervals, and more . .	8

Set up

```
library(tidyverse) # general use
library(janitor) # cleaning data frames
library(here) # file/folder organization
library(readxl) # reading .xlsx files
library(ggeffects) # generating model predictions
library(flextable) # creating tables
```

```
# abalone data from Hamilton et al. 2022
abalone <- read_xlsx(here("data", "Abalone IMTA_growth and pH.xlsx"))
```

Abalone example

Data from Hamilton et al. 2022. “Integrated multi-trophic aquaculture mitigates the effects of ocean acidification: Seaweeds raise system pH and improve growth of juvenile abalone.”
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.aquaculture.2022.738571>

a. Questions and hypotheses

Question: How does pH predict abalone growth (measured in change in shell surface area per day, $\text{mm}^2 \text{d}^{-1}$)?

H_0 : pH has no effect on abalone shell growth

H_A : pH does have an effect on abalone shell growth

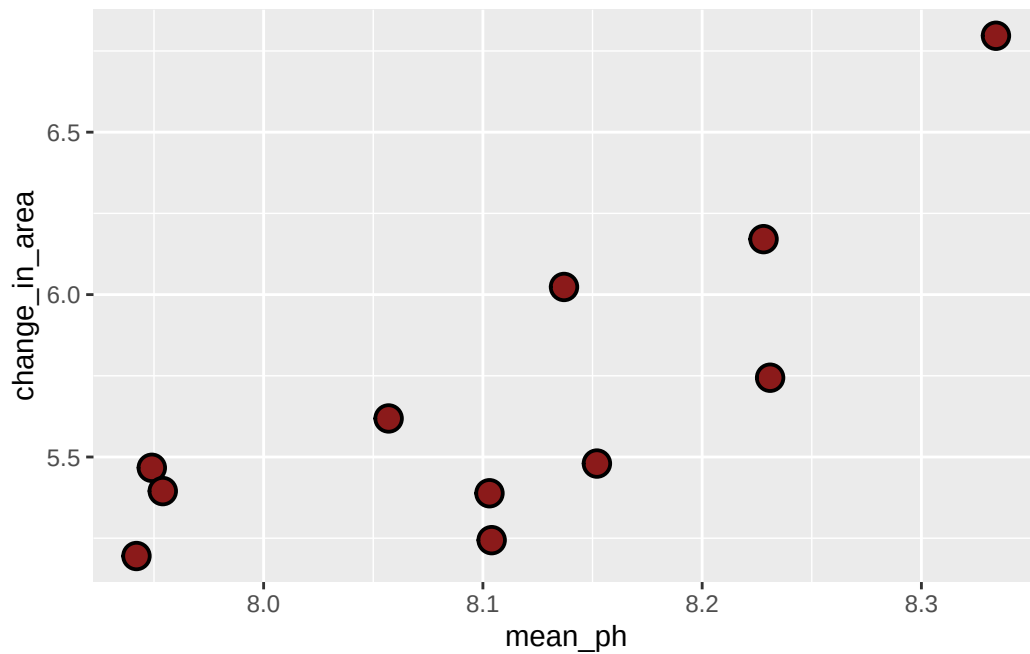
b. Cleaning

```
# created new object from abalone
abalone_clean <- abalone |>
  # cleaned column names (remove spaces and snake case)
  clean_names() |>
  # selected columns of interest
  select(mean_p_h, change_in_area_mm2_d_1_25) |>
  # renamed columns
  rename(mean_ph = mean_p_h,
         change_in_area = change_in_area_mm2_d_1_25)
```

Don't forget to look at your data! Use `View(abalone_clean)` in the Console.

c. Exploratory data visualization

```
# base layer: ggplot
ggplot(data = abalone_clean, # data frame: abalone clean
       aes(x = mean_ph, # x-axis: pH, y-axis: change in shell surface area/day
           y = change_in_area)) +
# first layer: points to represent operations
geom_point(size = 4,
           stroke = 1,
           fill = "firebrick4",
           shape = 21)
```



Where does the missing value come from?

The missing value comes from one pair of tanks in which the pH sensor malfunctioned.

Don't forget to turn your warnings off either in the individual code chunk or in the YAML at the top of the file.

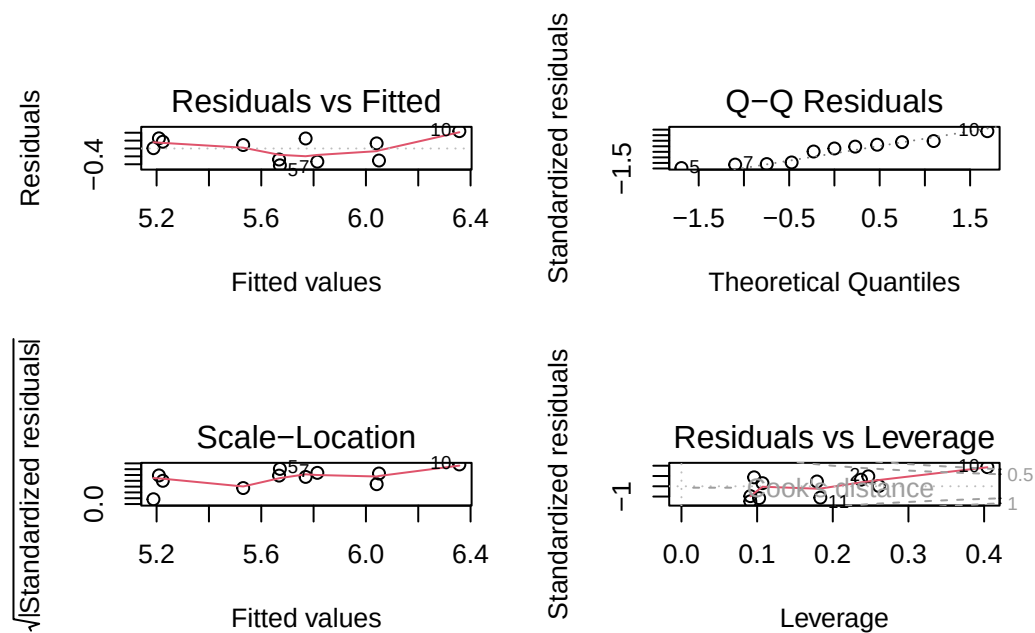
d. Abalone model

Model fitting

```
abalone_model <- lm(  
  change_in_area ~ mean_ph, # formula: change in shell SA/day as a function of pH  
  data = abalone_clean      # data frame: cleaned abalone data  
)
```

Diagnostics

```
par(mfrow = c(2, 2)) # displays plots in a 2x2 grid  
plot(abalone_model)  # displays diagnostic plots for model
```



Model summary

```
# more information about the model  
summary(abalone_model)
```

```

Call:
lm(formula = change_in_area ~ mean_ph, data = abalone_clean)

Residuals:
    Min       1Q   Median       3Q      Max
-0.42714 -0.29282  0.08769  0.21258  0.43965

Coefficients:
            Estimate Std. Error t value Pr(>|t|)
(Intercept) -18.5010     6.1601  -3.003  0.01488 *
mean_ph      2.9827     0.7596   3.926  0.00348 **
---
Signif. codes:  0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 0.3063 on 9 degrees of freedom
(1 observation deleted due to missingness)
Multiple R-squared:  0.6314,    Adjusted R-squared:  0.5905
F-statistic: 15.42 on 1 and 9 DF,  p-value: 0.003477

```

What is the slope estimate (with standard error?)

β_1 : 2.98 ± 0.76

What is the intercept estimate (with standard error?)

β : -18.50 ± 6.16

Generating predictions

```

# creating a new object called abalone_preds
abalone_preds <- ggpredict(
  abalone_model,      # model object
  terms = "mean_ph"  # predictor (in quotation marks)
)

# display the predictions
abalone_preds

```

Predicted values of change_in_area

mean_ph | Predicted | 95% CI

```
-----
7.94 |      5.19 | 4.83, 5.54
7.95 |      5.21 | 4.86, 5.55
8.06 |      5.53 | 5.30, 5.76
8.10 |      5.67 | 5.46, 5.88
8.10 |      5.67 | 5.46, 5.88
8.14 |      5.77 | 5.55, 5.98
8.15 |      5.81 | 5.59, 6.04
8.33 |      6.36 | 5.92, 6.80
```

Look at the column names using `colnames(abalone_preds)` in the Console.

What are the column names?

`x`, `predicted`, `std.error`, `conf.low`, `conf.high` (not going to worry about `group` right now)

Look at the actual object (by clicking on it in Environment).

Look at the class of the object using `class(abalone_preds)` in the Console.

What is this type of object?

It is a `ggeffects` output and a regular data frame.

View `abalone_preds` like a data frame.

Why generate model predictions?

This dataset does not include any actual observations of abalone growth at $\text{pH} = 8$.

However, the model can tell us a prediction for what abalone growth could be if $\text{pH} = 8$ based on the existing data.

Figure out what abalone growth the model would predict at $\text{pH} = 8$.

```
# finding the model prediction at a specific value
ggpredict(
  abalone_model,      # model object
  terms = "mean_ph[8]" # predictor (in quotation marks) and predictor value in brackets
)
```

Predicted values of `change_in_area`

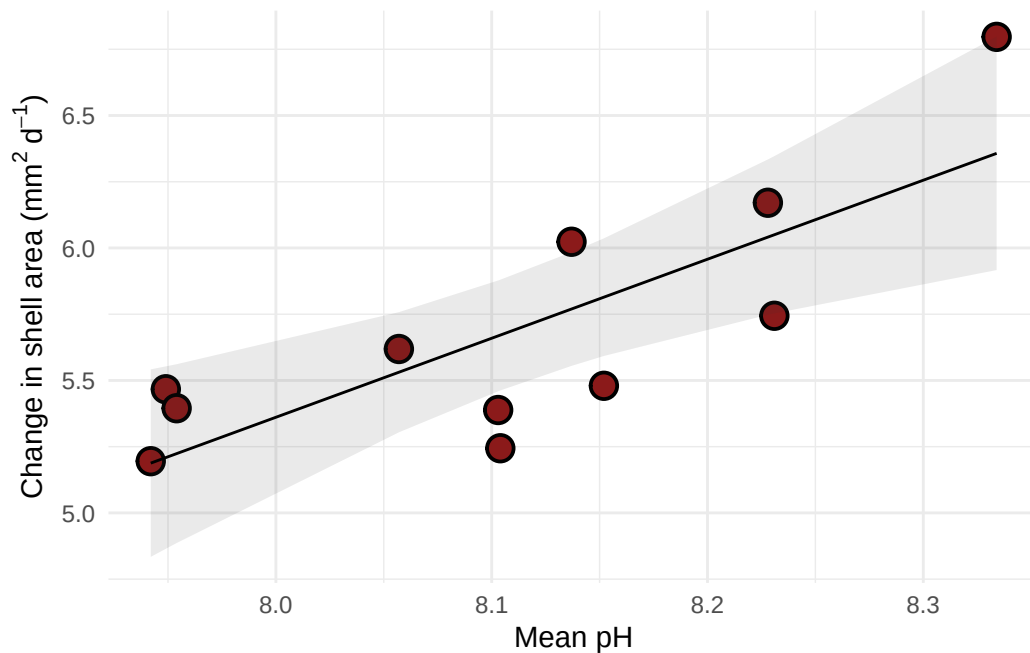
```
mean_ph | Predicted |      95% CI
-----
      8 |      5.36 | 5.08, 5.64
```

How would you interpret this?

At pH = 8, the model predicts a change in abalone shell surface area to be 5.36 [95% CI: 5.08, 5.64] ($\text{mm}^2 \text{d}^{-1}$).

Visualizing model predictions and data

```
# base layer: ggplot
# using clean data frame
ggplot(data = abalone_clean,
       aes(x = mean_ph,
           y = change_in_area)) +
# first layer: points representing abalones (scatter plot)
geom_point(size = 4,
           stroke = 1,
           fill = "firebrick4",
           shape = 21) +
# second layer: ribbon representing 95% confidence interval
# using predictions data frame
geom_ribbon(data = abalone_preds,
          aes(x = x,
              y = predicted,
              ymin = conf.low,
              ymax = conf.high),
          alpha = 0.1) +
# third layer: line representing model predictions
# using predictions data frame
geom_line(data = abalone_preds,
         aes(x = x,
             y = predicted)) +
# updated axis labels
labs(x = "Mean pH",
     y = expression("Change in shell area ("*mm^{2}*d^{-1}*")")) +
# changed theme
theme_minimal()
```



Creating a table with model coefficients, 95% confidence intervals, and more

Note: this function is from `flextable`.

```
as_flextable(abalone_model)
```

	Estimate	Standard Error	t value	Pr(> t)
(Intercept)	-18.501	6.160	-3.003	0.0149 *
mean_ph	2.983	0.760	3.926	0.0035 **

*Signif. codes: 0 <= '***' < 0.001 < '**' < 0.01 < '*' < 0.05*

Residual standard error: 0.3063 on 9 degrees of freedom

Multiple R-squared: 0.6314, Adjusted R-squared: 0.5905

F-statistic: 15.42 on 9 and 1 DF, p-value: 0.0035

END OF ABALONE EXAMPLE